Different perceptions of nationhood had led to the partition of India in 1947, but Pakistan faced the same problem in the 1960s. The basis of its nationhood was the idea of Islamic civilization. However, while they shared a religion, there were major cultural differences between East and West Pakistan. In the east, there was a strong sense of being Bengali. This was strengthened by resentment that political power lay in the hands of politicians and generals based in West Pakistan, who were blatantly insensitive to the needs of the east. It seemed that East Pakistan had just exchanged one form of colonialism with another. As Bengali demands gathered momentum, the response became more repressive. The openly expressed view by the West Pakistani military rulers was that the Bengalis were too influenced by Hindu culture. Particularly suspect was the significant Hindu Bengali population that had continued to live in East Pakistan. Frequent riots, supported tacitly by the State, broke out against the minorities in the mid-60s. Nonetheless, demands for autonomy and fairness continued to grow.

Once again, an act of nature triggered the sequence of events. In November 1970, a major tropical cyclone ‘Bhola’ struck East Pakistan and killed between 300,000 and 500,000 people. It is considered one of the worst natural disasters on record but, what really incensed the Bengali population was the lukewarm relief efforts of the military dictatorship. So when Pakistan’s military leaders finally allowed elections in late December, East Pakistan voted overwhelmingly for the Bengali-nationalist Awami League, which won 167 of 169 seats in the province. Since East Pakistan was more populous than West Pakistan, it raised the prospect that the Bengalis would now rule the country as a whole. This was certainly not palatable to the military brass or to Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, leader of the largest party in West Pakistan. The elections were ‘cancelled’ and East Pakistan broke into open revolt.

The military government of Yahya Khan responded by sending in the troops. The result was a genocide in which as many as three million people, particularly minorities and intellectuals, were killed. The residential halls of Dhaka University were particularly targeted. Up to 700 students were killed